CHAPTER 10 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

# Sharecropping & Debt

A system that kept Black (and many white) Southern farmers in a cycle of poverty that could last for generations. 1870s and beyond.

**Name:** _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

*A system that kept Black (and many white) Southern farmers in a cycle of poverty that could last for generations. 1870s and beyond.*

How can a person work hard all year, grow a valuable crop, and still end up poorer than when they started?

## A Year in the Life

THE SYSTEM

Most freedpeople had no land and no cash. So they farmed a landowner's land as sharecroppers, promising a large share of the harvest as rent. To survive until harvest, they bought seed, tools, and food on credit from the landowner's store — a system called the crop lien.

The interest was brutal — often 25% or more. When the crop was sold, the landowner subtracted the rent and the debt. Too often, the sharecropper's share didn't cover what he owed.

## Working Someone Else's Land

THE COTTON SOUTH

*Whole families worked from dawn to dark growing cotton they did not own, on land they could not leave until the debt — which rarely ended — was paid.*

*Picking cotton in the South — photograph, early 20th century, public domain (Library of Congress).*

## The debt grows

THE ARITHMETIC OF THE TRAP

Follow the math in the activity and you'll see the trap: a family could produce a good crop and still owe more at year's end than they had the year before.

And the law backed the landowner. A sharecropper in debt usually could not leave to find better terms — he was bound to work until the debt was paid. For many, it never was. This was debt peonage — bondage by ledger instead of by law.

*Redemption, 1869–77 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).*

## Slavery's Long Shadow

WHY IT MATTERS

Sharecropping was not slavery — families could not be sold, and they had legal rights slavery denied. But it reproduced slavery's core result: Black labor enriching white landowners, with Black families kept poor, immobile, and dependent.

The system trapped generations — Black and poor white alike — in the rural South, and its effects on wealth and opportunity echo to this day.

## Do the Math of the Trap

YOUR TURN

*You'll work through a sharecropper's yearly accounts and practice working with data — proving, with numbers, how the system kept families in debt.*